MARKETING GUIDE

Why Your Marketing Photos *Are Falling Flat*

You don't need to be a photographer to judge a great photo. You need the right questions.

PAUL PACEY



Before a parent reads a word, *your imagery has already spoken.*

Your school only gets one first impression. Long before prospective parents read about your curriculum or values, your imagery has already created an instant emotional connection, or a subtle reason to move on. Knowing which is easier than you think.

You don't need to be a photographer to judge a photograph objectively. *You need four simple questions.*

FOUR SIMPLE QUESTIONS

01 Does it look good? — AESTHETIC

02 Does it feel good? — EMOTION

03 Does it tell a story? — NARRATIVE

04 *Is it believable?* — AUTHENTICITY

01

Does it look good?

The foundation, not the finish. A technically solid image isn't enough on its own, but every other layer is built on it. It's also where a surprising number of school images already fall short.

- **Exposure:** Is it too dark or too light? Can you clearly see the faces?
- **Composition:** Does it feel balanced? Is anything awkwardly cut off? Is there more in the frame than it needs?
- **Focus:** Is it obvious what the image is about? Is that subject sharp when you zoom in?
- **Light:** Is the light flattering to faces, or flat, harsh and full of shadows?
- **Color:** Do skin tones look natural and healthy?


01 Does it look good?
02 Does it feel good?
03 Does it tell a story?
04 *Is it believable?*

02

Does it feel good?

An emotionally charged photo—even one with technical flaws—will always beat a technically perfect image that feels empty. Capturing genuine emotion is the hardest part of visual storytelling, but when combined with true authenticity, it becomes the single most powerful driver of trust and connection.

- **Feeling:** Does it express a positive emotion or state of mind, such as joy, curiosity, focus, pride or belonging?
- **Expressions:** Are they genuine, or performed for the camera?
- **Connection:** Is there a bond between people, or between a student and their work?
- **Relatability:** Could a parent picture their own child in this moment?
- **Impact:** Does it make *you* feel something?


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03

Does it tell a story?

Narrative is the context behind your message: who's there, what's happening, and why it matters.

- **Moment:** Does the image tell a story?
- **Clarity:** Is it understood at a glance, or does it need explaining?
- **Engagement:** Are people engaged with each other or their work, rather than posing for the camera?

EXCEPTION TO THE RULE

Sometimes, less is more. For hero imagery—like poster or billboard shots—a busy narrative can actually distract. A clean, minimal focus on a single student or teacher creates a stronger visual impact and leaves room for headline copy and graphics to deliver the message.

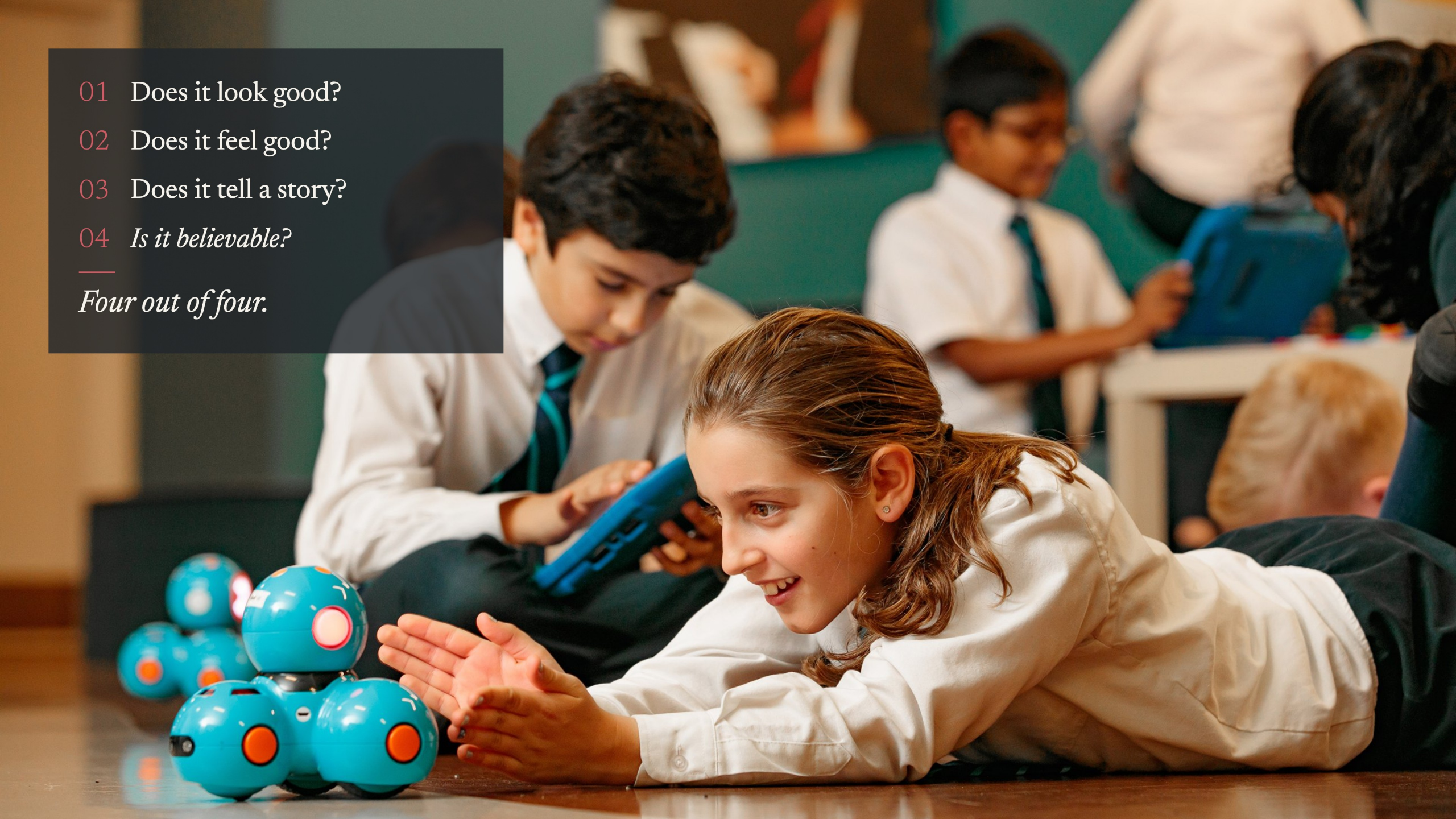

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04

Is it believable?

An image can look good, feel good, tell a story—and still fail completely if it isn't believable. Instead of building trust, a clearly manufactured image signals that the reality of your school doesn't match the marketing.

- **Unscripted:** Does the moment look and feel natural, or does everything look a little *too* rigid or orchestrated?
- **Spontaneous:** Is there an unmistakable sense of an unplanned moment or interaction?
- **Credible:** Do the props and subjects belong in the space, or do they feel out of place?



01 Does it look good?

02 Does it feel good?

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Four out of four.

SPOT THE GAP

Let’s put it *to the test.*

Four images, each missing one piece. Ask the four questions and see if you can spot which.



SPOT THE GAP · 1 OF 4

Which piece *is missing?*

01 Aesthetic

02 Emotion

03 Narrative

04 Authenticity

Decide before you turn the page.



SPOT THE GAP · 2 OF 4

Which piece *is missing?*

01 Aesthetic

02 Emotion

03 Narrative

04 Authenticity

Decide before you turn the page.



SPOT THE GAP · 3 OF 4

Which piece *is missing?*

01 Aesthetic

02 Emotion

03 Narrative

04 Authenticity

Decide before you turn the page.



SPOT THE GAP · 4 OF 4

Which piece *is missing?*

01 Aesthetic

02 Emotion

03 Narrative

04 Authenticity

Decide before you turn the page.

SPOT THE GAPS · ANSWERS

How did *you do?*



1

MISSING

Emotion

Well lit and well composed. Clear narrative, but emotionally a little flat.



2

MISSING

Authenticity

Polished and pleasant, but clearly performative. Doesn't fool anybody.



3

MISSING

Aesthetic

Right moment, wrong light: dull skin tones and faces lost in shadow.



4

MISSING

Narrative

But as a hero image, it doesn't need a story. Still great.

All images by Paul Pacey, except round 2 (AI-generated).

THE STANDARD

Great imagery isn’t left *to chance.*

Great school marketing photography comes from creating the right environment, knowing what to look for, and holding your visuals to the highest standards—one image at a time.

Now, how do your own images *stack up?*

If the honest answer is “not quite,” let’s *talk* and close the gap.

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